Optimal Dynamic Pricing With Preferences for Novelty

Tate Mason

The University of Georgia

November 11, 2026

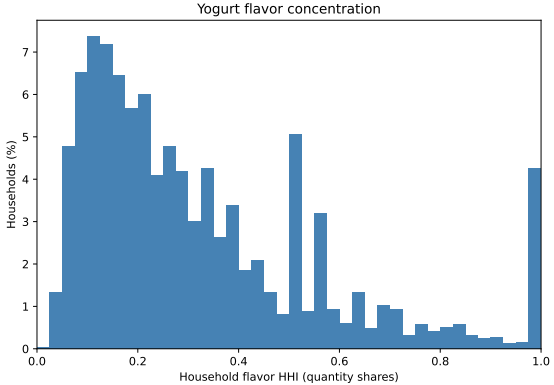
Motivation

- Across repeated interactions with a firm, consumer preferences may evolve
- Novelty, habit, boredom all contribute to consumption patterns varying across time
- Allows for targeted discounting based on past choices and preference dynamics
- Targeted discounts allow firms to steer consumers toward particular products.

What is Novelty

DO LIKE RACHEL

Novelty Motivation



- NUMBER OF SWITCHES PER HH
- NUMBER OF UNIQUE FLAVORS

Flavor Popularity

Research Question

How can firms price discriminate via consumer preferences for novelty and habit and how much is information about these preferences worth?

- Propose and solve a theoretical two-period supply model when consumer's exhibit heterogeneous preferences for novelty
- Estimate demand for yogurt and recover distribution of novelty preferences
- Apply estimated distribution to supply model to quantify theoretical gains from personalized pricing

▸ Flavor Popularity

Literature

Dynamic Targeting:

- Dubé (2008), Anand & Shachar (2009), Karle & Reisinger (2024), Durrmeyer, Fournel, Samano (2026)
- Contribution: Firm pricing based off of novelty with varying levels of information on consumers.

Estimating preferences for novelty:

- McAllister (1982), Lattin (1987), Chintagunta (1999), Ackerberg (2003), Dubé (2004), Dubé et. al (2021)
- Contribution: Recovering a distribution for preferences over novelty in consumption to be used in a pricing exercise

Pricing with State Dependence

- Klemperer (198x), Dubé et. al (2022),GO THROUGH ZOTERO
- Contribution: Modeling novelty rather than habit as driver for differential pricing.

Supply Setting

- Monopolistic firm producing a single product j
- A consumer is born into the world with a type and an initial purchase state:

  Consumer Type

  $$r = \{H, L\}$$

  Initial Purchase

  $$h_0 = \{0, j\}$$

- Consumers live for two periods, purchasing the inside good or opting for the outside good in each period
- The firm knows h_0 &γ_r, setting prices to individual consumers by type and history

Consumer's Problem

$$V_{jt}^{inside} = \underbrace{\beta}_{\text{Constant}} + \overbrace{\gamma_r \mathbb{1}\{h_t = 0\}}^{\text{Utilty from Switching}} - \underbrace{\alpha p_t(h_t)}_{\text{Price Disutility}}, \quad V_{0t}^{Outside} = \underbrace{\gamma_r \mathbb{1}\{h_t = j\}}_{\text{Utility from Switching}}$$

$$v_t(x) = V_{jt}^{inside} - V_{0t}^{outside} = \beta + \underbrace{\gamma[\mathbb{1}\{h_t = 0\} - \mathbb{1}\{h_t = j\}]}_{q(h_t)} - \alpha p_t(h_t)$$

- Prices and switching utility depend on history $h_t = x_{t-1}$

Firm's Problem

$$\pi_t(h) = \max_{p_t(h)} s_t(h)[p_t(h) - c]$$

$$\Pi(h) = \underbrace{s_1(h)(p_1(h) - c)}_{\text{Margin in Period 1}} + \underbrace{\delta\{s_1(h)\pi_2(j) + (1 - s_1(h))\pi_2(0)\}}_{\text{Continuation Value}}$$

- Firm profits are comprised of period one margins given initial state and the expected value of that consumer given their period one choice

First Period Optimization

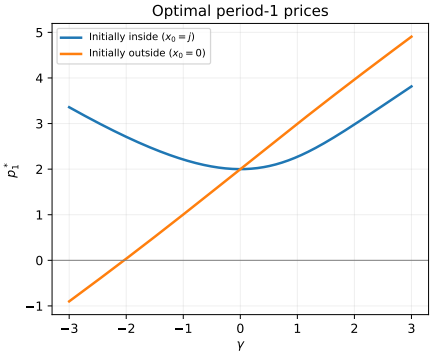
$$\frac{d\Pi}{dp_1(h_0)} = s_1 + \frac{\partial}{\partial p_1(h_0)} s_1(h_0)[p_1(h_0) - c + \delta(\pi_2(j) - \pi_2(0))]$$

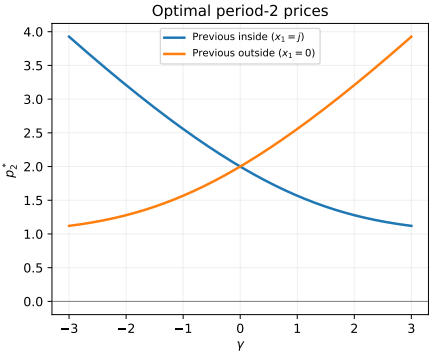
$$p_1^*(h_0) = c + \frac{1}{\alpha(1 - s_1^*(h_0))} - \delta(\pi_2(j) - \pi_2(0))$$

$$\Pi^*(h_t) = \delta\pi_2(0) + \frac{s_1^*(h_0)}{\alpha(1 - s_1^*(h_0))}$$

Terminal FOC Comparative statics Elasticities

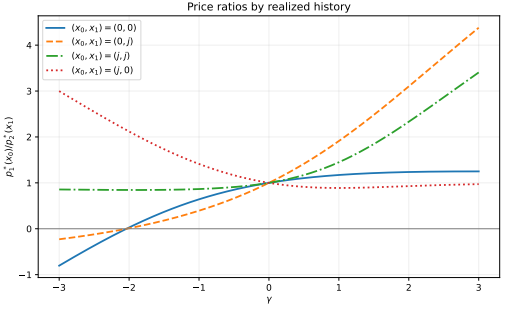
Optimal Prices

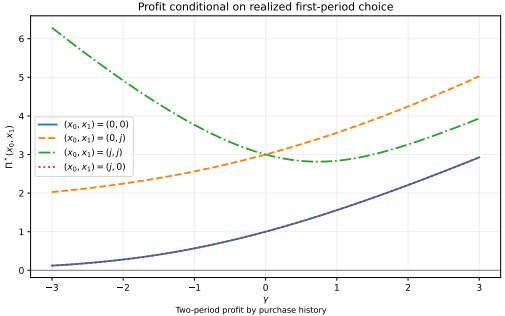




Calibration Table Profit Price ratio Discussion

Optimal Price Ratios and Profit





$\delta = 1$: no discounting. Flavor is j; outside is everything except that flavor.

▸ Optimal prices ▸ Profit detail ▸ Price-ratio detail

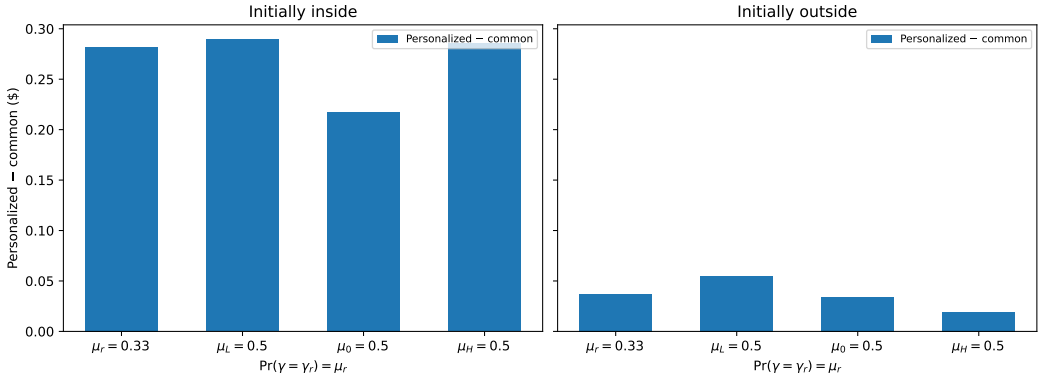
Information Friction: Fixed Beliefs about Switching Type

$$s_t(h_1) = \sum_r \mu_r \, s_t(h \mid \gamma_r),$$

$$\pi_2(h_1) = \max_{p_2(h_1)} s_2(h_1) \, [p_2(h_1) - c].$$

- Initial purchase history is observed.
- $\gamma_L = -1.25$, $\gamma_0 = 0$, $\gamma_H = 1.25$.
- $\Pr(\gamma = \gamma_r) = \mu_r$, $r \in \{H, 0, L\}$. Equal case: $\mu_r = 0.33$.
- Other cases: each permutation of $(0.50, 0.25, 0.25)$.
- Type probabilities stay fixed in both periods, after either purchase outcome.
- Offers depend on observed history; there is no learning about type.

Personalized vs Common Pricing



Profit levels Price paths Price paths

Data Sources

Nielsen HomeScan

- Provides household level purchase data
- Covers years 2006-2015
- Products chosen, quantity chosen, timing of trips

Nielsen RetailScan

- Provides store level product data
- For specified product category: prices, markets, product attributes

Sample Selection

- Must be single-person household
- Must be seen at least 2 times
- Purchases must be made at Nielsen store (prices available)
- Flavor attribute must be present

Activity

Sample Statistics: Demographics

Table: Summary statistics: full sample and yogurt sample

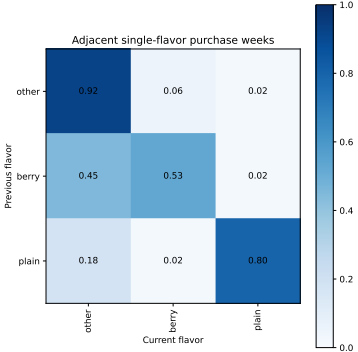
	Full sample	Yogurt sample
Sample and purchase activity		
Households	37,827	15,106
Mean observed panel years	3.96	3.16
Mean trips per approximate observed week	2.27	0.11
Mean distinct UPCs per household	1,178.31	13.89
Mean head age	45-49	50-54
Mean household income	$30,000-$35,000	$35,000-$39,999
Race: White (%)	80.33	81.58
Race: Black (%)	12.81	12.15
Race: Asian (%)	1.57	1.57
Race: Other (%)	2.19	2.11
Hispanic (%)	3.10	2.59

Switching Stats

Table: Matched yogurt sample: purchase dynamics

metric	value
Matched households	15106.00
Observed yogurt purchase weeks	282648.00
Mean flavors bought per household	1.93
Mean household flavor HHI (0 to 1)	0.78
Mixed-flavor weeks (%)	17.45
Weeks above seven packages (%)	21.72
Eligible adjacent single-flavor week pairs	48166.00
Switch rate in eligible pairs (%)	12.85
Mean single-flavor spell length (consecutive calendar weeks)	1.22
Median gap between purchase weeks	3.00

Persistence Across Aggregated Flavor Groups



Plain repeats in approximately 80% of eligible transitions, versus 53% for berry.

Demand Setting and Objective

- Consumers can either purchase the inside good, a flavor of yogurt, or the outside good, not yogurt
- Consumers differ in preferences for novelty and price sensitivity, but derive the same base utility from the three flavor categories
- Goal: Recover distribution of novelty preferences

Demand Model

$$U_{ijt} = \beta_0 + \beta_j X_{jt} + \gamma_i N_{ijt} + \phi_i H_{ijt} + \alpha_i p_{jt} + \varepsilon_{ijt}, \qquad U_{i0t} = \varepsilon_{i0t}.$$

Household i's share of yogurt purchases in flavor j in week t is

$$w_{ijt} = \frac{y_{ijt}}{\sum_k y_{ikt}}.$$

Novelty

$$N_{ijt} = \begin{cases} 1 - w_{ij,t-1}, & \text{if yogurt bought in } t-1, \\ 0, & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

Habit

$$H_{ijt} = \sum_{s<t} w_{ijs}.$$

Following Nevo (2001), a week contains seven choice opportunities with observed flavor purchases treated as fulfilling an opportunity

Define outside good as $\max(0, 7 - \sum_j x_{jt})$, or the difference in purchases and a full week

Estimation

$$P_i(\theta) = \int P(y_i \mid \nu, \theta)\ \phi(\nu)\, d\nu$$

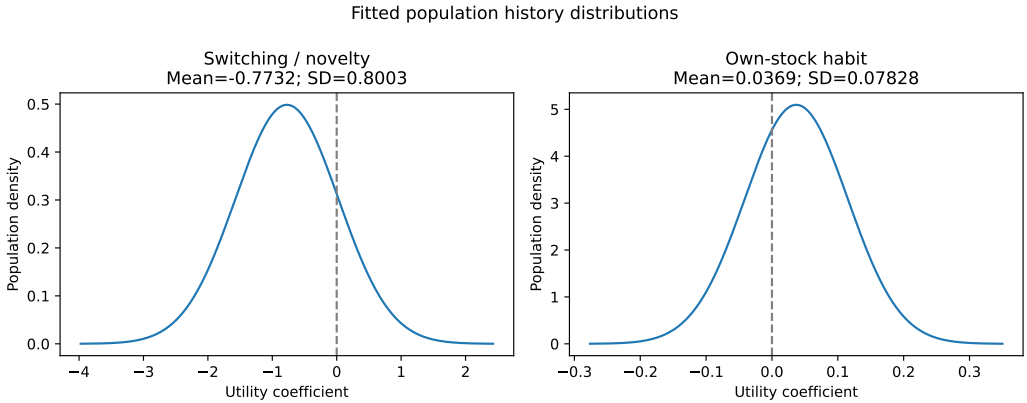
$$\widehat{P}_i(\theta) = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{r=1}^{n} \prod_{t=1}^{T_i} P(y_i \mid \nu_{ir}, \theta) \qquad \nu_{ir} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, I)$$

$$G_{128}(\theta) = -\sum_{i=1}^{N} \log \widehat{P}_i(\theta)$$

- ν_i captures unobserved heterogeneity, y_{it} represents observed choice, $\theta = \{\gamma, \phi, \alpha\}$ is the vector of heterogeneous demand parameters
- n = 128 draws per household from a normal distribution

Probabilities Price controls Controlled estimates First stages

Distributions



Estimates Discussion

Implied Willingness to Pay

Table: Implied willingness to pay without price controls

Utility term	Mean WTP	Population SD
Inside constant β_0	2.7474	2.7716
Berry vs. other	-1.4085	1.4210
Plain vs. other	-0.6137	0.6192
novelty	-1.7451	3.1116
own stock	0.0833	0.2647

- Would need to be subsidized to switch, though lots of variation
- Willing to pay to continue consuming their same product

Controlled WTP

Connecting Supply and Demand

Supply Theory

- Today's pricing offer changes tomorrow's demand
- Single product firm pricing to attract customers against outside option
- Maintain two-period timing with initial state

Empirical Demand

- Employ estimated preference for novelty
- Access observed purchase histories
- Novelty and habit both enter demand

Complete Information: Type-Specific Offers

- The firm observes $\gamma_r \ \forall \ r = \{H, L\}, \ h_0 = \{0, j\}$
- Use estimated bottom and top quartiles from distribution of γ_i as the low and high groups, medium group is assusmed to derive no utility from switching.
- The firm chooses p_1 and decides p_2 after observing the first-period choice.

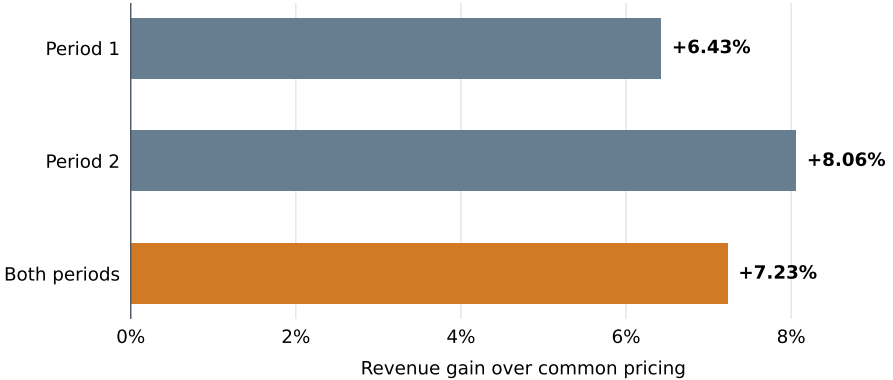
What If Switching Type Is Hidden?

- The firm observes initial state h_0, but now does not know individual γ_r.
- It knows the distribution of low, medium, and high switching types.
- The firm's type probabilities stay fixed across periods but it can offer dynamic pricing.

Common Pricing When Type Is Hidden

- Choose a single offer for all types with the same observed history to maximize expected two-period revenue.
- The offer can vary with $h_0,\ h_1$.
- For the price-path comparison, the firm assigns probability $1/3$ to each type.

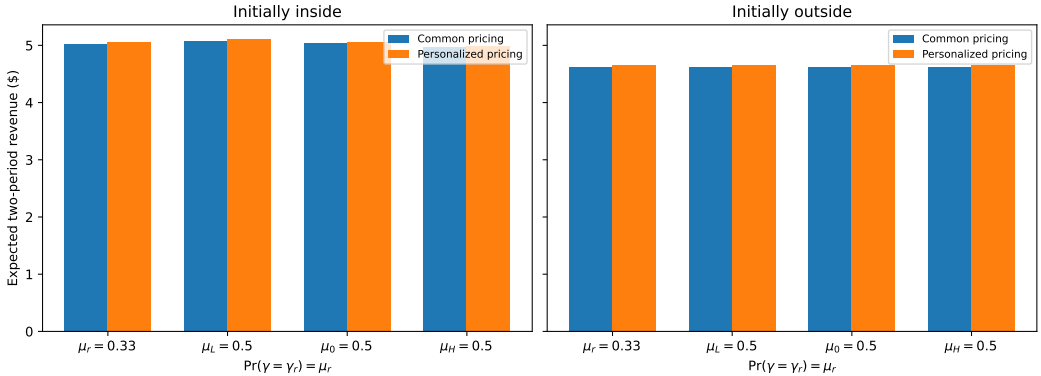
Plain: Revenue Gain from Personalized Pricing



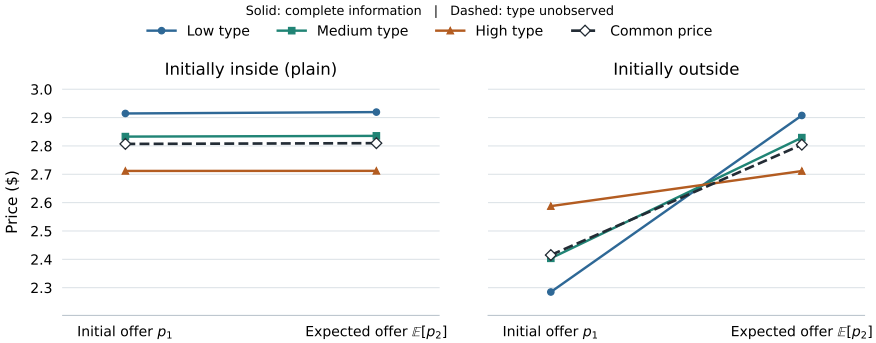
Coupon exercise for plain.

Plain types

Plain: Revenue with Observed or Hidden Types



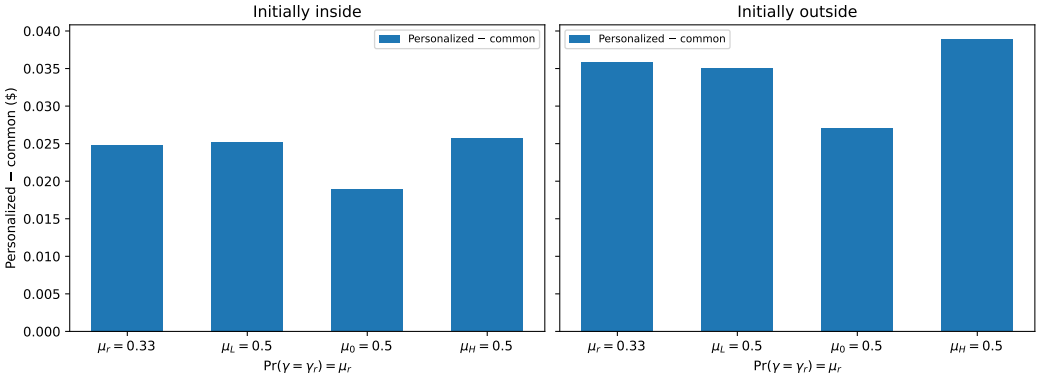
Plain: Type-Specific and Common Price Paths



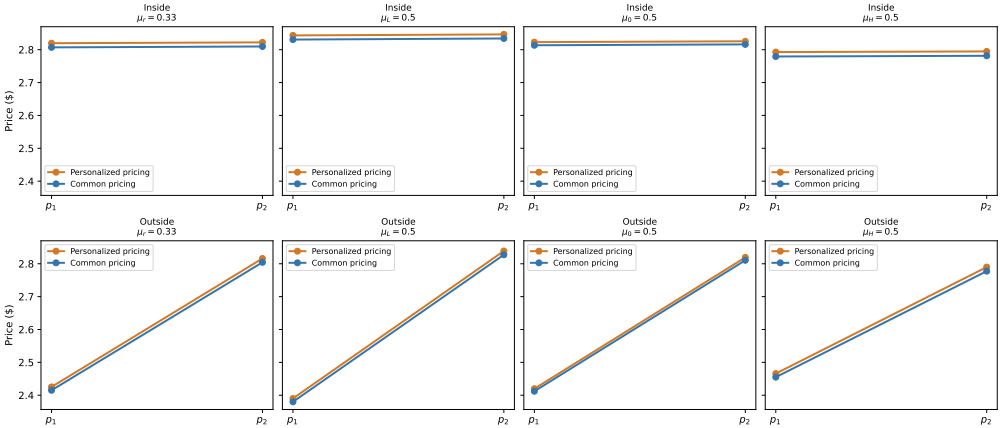
Common offers use equal type probabilities. Terminal offers are averaged over first-period choices.

▸ Coupon offers

Plain: Personalized vs Common Pricing



Plain: Price Paths under Type Uncertainty (p_1 to p_2)



Plain: Expected Revenue by Initial State and Prior

Initial state	Prior	Personalized pricing	Common pricing	Difference
j	Equal types	5.0508	5.0259	0.0249
0	Equal types	4.6564	4.6205	0.0358
j	Low type more likely	5.1033	5.0781	0.0252
0	Low type more likely	4.6501	4.6151	0.0350
j	Medium type more likely	5.0584	5.0396	0.0189
0	Medium type more likely	4.6553	4.6282	0.0271
j	High type more likely	4.9906	4.9649	0.0257
0	High type more likely	4.6637	4.6248	0.0389

j denotes plain and 0 denotes the outside option.

Conclusion

- For plain, personalized pricing raises simulated two-period revenue from \$11,615.34 to \$12,455.27 (+7.23%)
- Consumers experience disutility from switching, needing to be subsidized $\approx \$1.75$ to switch products
- Consumers enjoy habit and would be willing to pay $\$0.083$ to contribute another unit to the product's share of purchase history

Next Steps

- Add firm learning to supply side
- Extend market structure on supply
- Add more product attributes to empirical estimation
- Estimate unobserved quality in BLP fashion

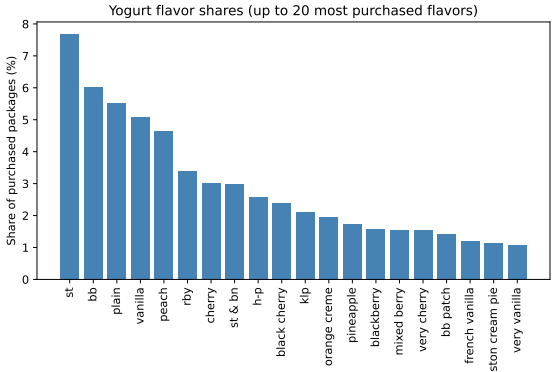
Sample Statistics: Purchase Activity

	Full sample	Yogurt sample
Households	37,827	15,106
Observed panel years	3.96	3.16
Trips per household	493.13	20.26
Trips per observed week (approx.)	2.27	0.11
Distinct UPCs per household	1,178.31	13.89
Purchase lines per household	3,397.64	45.15
Packages per household	4,669.07	93.77

All statistics except household counts are means.

Back to Data Sources

Flavor Popularity



Back to HHI

Optimal Terminal Price and Profit

$$\frac{\partial \pi_2(h_1)}{\partial p_2(h_1)} = s_2(h_1) + (p_2 - c)\frac{\partial s_2(h_1)}{\partial p_2(h_1)}$$

$$p_2^*(h_1) = c + \frac{1}{\alpha(1 - s_2^*(h_1))}$$

$$\pi_2^*(p_2^*(h_1); h_1) = \frac{s_2^*(h_1)}{\alpha(1 - s_2^*(h_1))}$$

- Optimal period two price is cost plus a demand markup term
- Period two profit at optimal prices is the odds of purchase, scaled by the inverse price sensitivity

Back to First Period Optimization

Optimal Profit Given Switching Type

$$\frac{d\Pi}{d\gamma} = \frac{q(h)s_1^*(h) - \delta s_1^*(h)s_2^*(j) + \delta(1 - s_1^*(h))s_2^*(0)}{\alpha}$$

- There are two interpretations:
  1. If $h_0 = j$, $q(h) < 0$, leading us to ambiguous signage as we raise profits from initially outside consumers but see opposing forces for the initially inside: leave in period one, return in period two
  2. If $h_0 = 0$, $q(h) > 0 \Rightarrow \frac{d\Pi}{d\gamma} > 0$, meaning that profits increase as γ increases
- Points to firms potentially reaping great benefit from knowing consumer types and histories

Back to First Period Optimization

Shares and Elasticities

$$s_t(h) = \frac{e^{v_t(h)}}{1 + e^{v_t(h)}}, \;\; s_{0t}(h) = 1 - s_t(h)$$

$$\frac{\partial s_t(h)}{\partial p_t(h)} = -\alpha s_t(h)(1 - s_t(h))$$

$$\frac{\partial s_t(h)}{\partial \gamma} = q(h) s_t(h)(1 - s_t(h))$$

Back to First Period Optimization

Pricing Simulations Specification

Parameter	Description	Value
β	Inside-good intercept	2
α	Price sensitivity	1
δ	Discount factor (no discounting)	1
c	Marginal cost	0
γ	Switching preference	$[-3, 3]$
Initial Consumption State		$h_0 \in \{0, j\}$
Feasible Prices		$p_t(h) \in \mathbb{R}$

- Allow for negative pricing
- Firm has knowledge of both type and history, allowing for targeted pricing
- Four consumption histories possible $(h_0, h_1) \in \{(0,0), (0,j), (j,j), (j,0)\}$

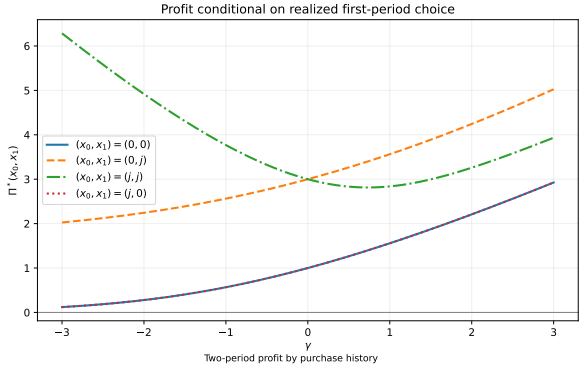
Back to Optimal Prices

Results

x_0	γ	p_1^*	$p_2^*(j)$	$p_2^*(0)$	Π^*	$\Pi^{*\prime}$
j	-3	3.358	3.926	1.120	5.284	-1.445
j	-1	2.211	2.557	1.567	2.768	-0.993
j	0	2.000	2.000	2.000	2.000	-0.500
j	1	2.271	1.567	2.557	1.838	0.177
j	3	3.814	1.120	3.926	2.934	0.730
0	-3	-0.901	3.926	1.120	1.026	0.177
0	-1	1.005	2.557	1.567	1.562	0.376
0	0	2.000	2.000	2.000	2.000	0.500
0	1	2.995	1.567	2.557	2.562	0.624
0	3	4.905	1.120	3.926	4.025	0.823

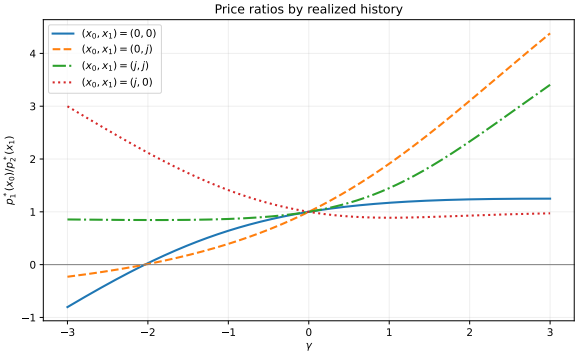
Back to Optimal Prices

Optimal Profit



Back to Optimal Prices

Optimal Price Ratio



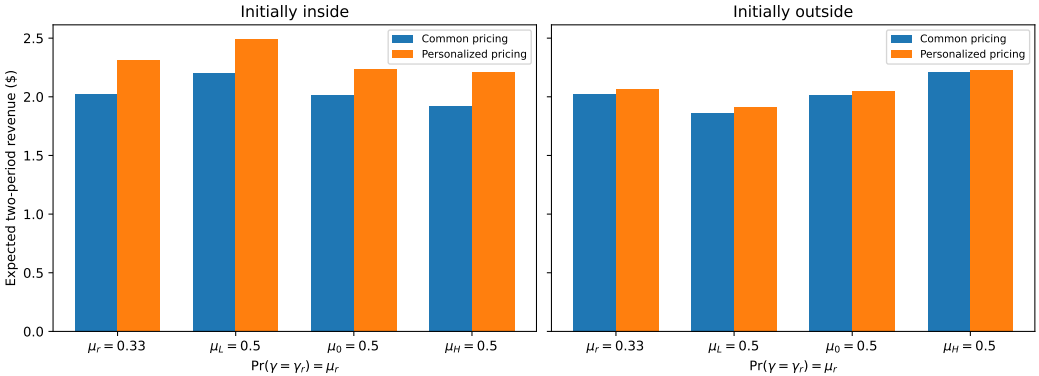
Back to Optimal Prices

Discussion

- Two mechanisms: Induce and harvest, Retain and gain
- Most profit from those who are habitual inside purchasers
- Least profit from those who purchase outside in period 1 across all levels of gamma
- Interesting when (j, j) and $(0, 0)$ cross

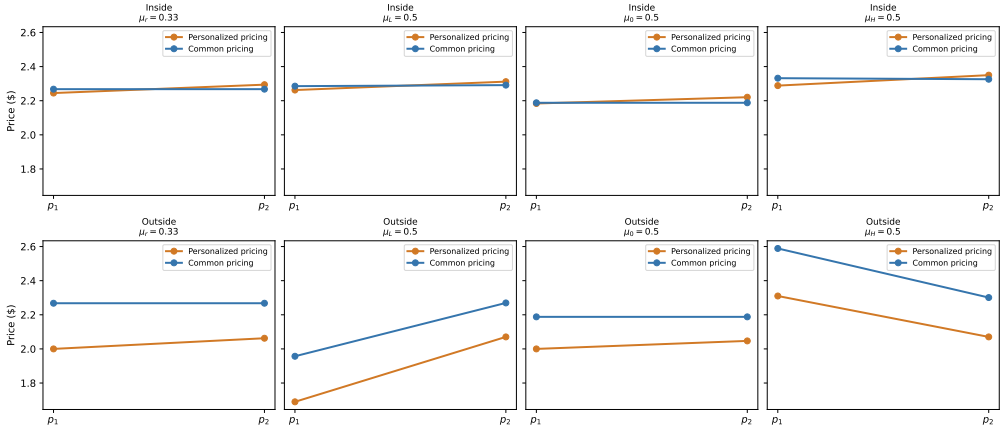
Back to Optimal Prices

Known versus Uncertain Switching Type



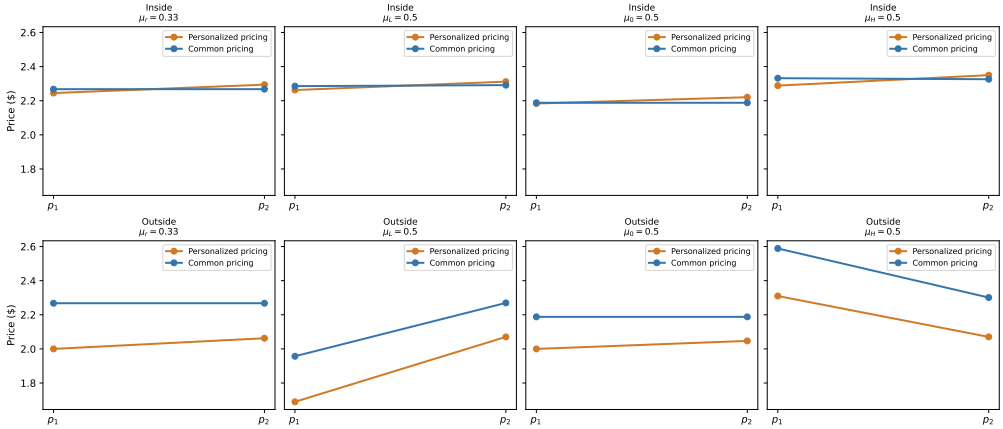
Back to Personalized vs Common Pricing

Type Uncertainty: Price Paths



▸ Back to Personalized vs Common Pricing

Type Uncertainty: Price Paths



▸ Back to Personalized vs Common Pricing

Probability and Shares

$$P_{ijt} = \frac{\exp\{V_{ijt}\}}{1 + \sum_{k \in J} \exp\{V_{ikt}\}}$$

$$\text{s.t. } V_{ijt} = U_{ijt} - \varepsilon_{ijt}$$

$$s_{jt} = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{n=1}^{N} P_{ijt}$$

- Use deterministic utility to form purchase probabilities
- Take average probability for product j across individuals $i \in N$ to recover shares

Back to Estimation

Demand: Price-Control Comparison

Table: Demand estimates with and without price controls; standard errors in parentheses

Parameter	No controls	With controls
Mean novelty	-0.7732 (0.0095)	-0.7861 (0.0091)
Mean habit	0.0369 (0.0002)	0.0373 (0.0002)
SD novelty	0.8003 (0.0085)	0.7999 (0.0082)
SD habit	0.0783 (0.0004)	0.0793 (0.0004)

Back to Estimation

Controlled Demand Estimates

Table: Demand estimates with price controls

Parameter	Estimate	Standard error
Inside constant β_0	1.4762	0.0072
Berry vs. other	-0.6556	0.0034
Plain vs. other	-0.1192	0.0066
Mean price coefficient $E[\alpha_i]$	-1.0349	0.0051
Mean novelty	-0.7861	0.0091
Mean habit	0.0373	0.0002
SD price coefficient $\mathrm{SD}(\alpha_i)$	0.7957	0.0063
SD novelty	0.7999	0.0082
SD habit	0.0793	0.0004
Price control ρ	0.1959	0.0047

Back to Estimation

Controlled Fit: Price First Stages

Table: Price first stages for the controlled specification

Flavor	IV slope	Cluster SE	F	Partial R^2
Other	-34.680	0.966	1288.26	0.0213
Berry	-33.105	1.377	578.20	0.0192
Plain	-28.585	3.085	85.87	0.0076

Back to Estimation

Estimates

Table: Demand estimates without price controls

Parameter	Estimate	Standard error
Inside constant β_0	1.2173	0.0035
Berry vs. other	-0.6241	0.0034
Plain vs. other	-0.2719	0.0054
Mean price coefficient $E[\alpha_i]$	-0.8940	0.0044
Mean novelty	-0.7732	0.0095
Mean habit	0.0369	0.0002
SD price coefficient $\mathrm{SD}(\alpha_i)$	0.9019	0.0099
SD novelty	0.8003	0.0085
SD habit	0.0783	0.0004

Back to Distributions

Discussion

- Mean novelty effect is equivalent to $\approx \$1.75$ increase
- Habit provides some utility
- Both plain and berry are less preferred than other flavors

How can the firm use the distribution of switching types to price discriminate?

Back to Distributions

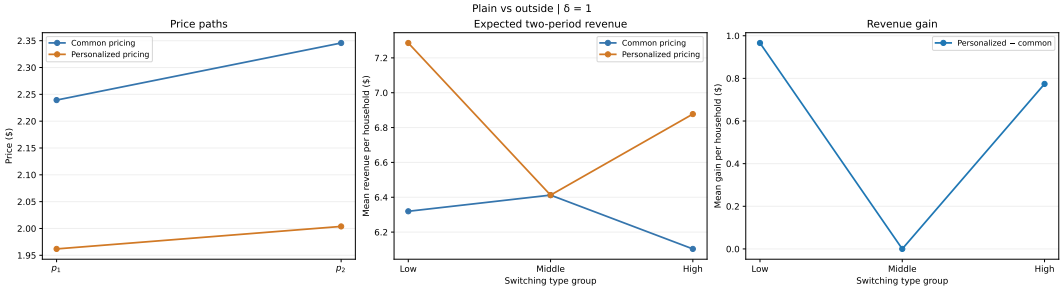
Controlled Fit: Willingness to Pay

Table: Implied willingness to pay with price controls

Utility term	Mean WTP	Population SD
Inside constant β_0	2.2696	1.7451
Berry vs. other	-1.0081	0.7751
Plain vs. other	-0.1832	0.1409
novelty	-1.2086	1.8083
own stock	0.0574	0.1600

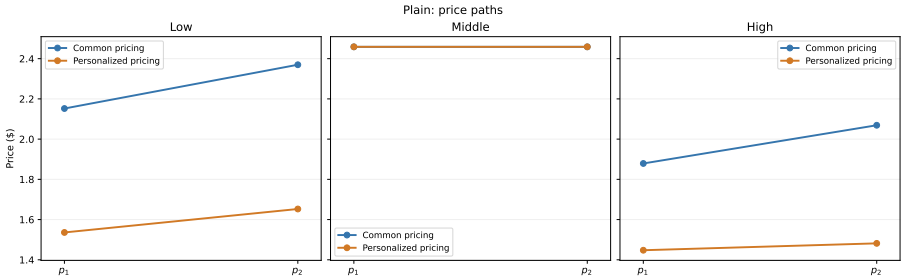
Back to Implied Willingness to Pay

Results: Plain Inside



Back to Revenue Gain

Plain: Optimal Offers by Consumer Type



Back to Price Paths